

World Index, FTSE4Good, Domini 400 Social Index and others to guide investment decisions. These funds have already channelled large amount of investors' savings into companies that have high social brand capital.

• **India has witnessed some welcome developments in this direction in recent years.** The ABN Amro Bank launched a Sustainable Development Fund as India's first Socially Responsible Investing Fund. Recently CRISIL, S&P and KLD have announced that they would develop an Environmental, Social and Corporate Governance (ESG) Index of Indian companies. The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India is also reported to be working on developing a similar evaluation.

• **Individual investors**, while seeking to maximise returns from their portfolio holdings, **could exercise a powerful choice for companies with high Triple Bottom Line performance.**

• Banks and Financial Institutions could ask for voluntary disclosures and **factor the rating in their lending evaluations.**

Fourth, the role of Civil Society organisations.

• Consumer awareness will benefit immensely if **civil society organisations and consumer bodies actively advocate the usage of Trustmarks.** They could also promote awareness amongst constituents to support products and services of companies with higher Sustainability ratings.

• **Schools and educational institutions could also promote awareness on responsible corporate behaviour** and its association with the Trustmark ratings on products and services, and design elements in their curriculum to groom citizens of tomorrow as enlightened consumers.

• And finally, **the Media**, as one of the most powerful forces of shaping public opinion, **can make a multi-dimensional contribution in this direction.**

It is my strong belief that by aligning such powerful forces, **we will see the emergence of a new consciousness where CSR will transcend from corporate philanthropy to a competitive value proposition.**

Your Company has been instrumental in setting up the **CII-ITC Centre of Excellence for Sustainable Development**, which is a unique institution that seeks to address the void in developing requisite capability on Sustainability issues among Indian industry. The Centre endeavours to bring about transformational change in Indian businesses by providing thought leadership, promoting awareness and building capacity. One of the major initiatives of the CII-ITC Centre is to recognise excellence in Sustainability practices by presenting Awards to industry, based on a rigorous process of selection. This attempt to recognise outstanding Sustainability initiatives is designed not only to celebrate individual corporate action, but also to inspire others to follow.

I am convinced that in today's enlightened India, more and more companies will respond to the appeal made by the Hon'ble Prime Minister to forge partnerships for social action, and achieve growth with efficiency and inclusivity. Making markets work for CSR will indeed provide the compelling foundation for such initiatives.

MAKING A DIFFERENCE

The essence of what I have presented to you today is a considered response to enhancing corporate participation in societal development. Your Company has been at the forefront in providing both thought leadership and action in creating a more secure, sustainable and inclusive future. It is true that no single organ of society will be able to make a significant difference based on their individual action. However, the efforts made by your Company demonstrate that with innovation, commitment and by forging enduring partnerships, we can all make a difference.



Indeed, the challenges seem daunting when we witness the scale of inequity and poverty. The good news is that never before in world history have we possessed so much knowledge, technology and resources to deal with this apparently hopeless situation. **It is indeed heartening to witness a growing corporate consciousness to ensure that the future generations are more secure.** I hope this groundswell of effort will continue to grow and become a committed movement for a better tomorrow.

I firmly believe that Corporates in India have the capability, the vision and the entrepreneurial skill to forge a more prosperous future for the nation, even as they sharpen their competitiveness and grow their businesses globally. Mahatma Gandhi said, and I quote : *"The difference between what we do and what we are capable of doing would suffice to solve most of the world's problems"*. We need to heed this message to realise our fullest potential.

To be able to stand tall amidst adversity, to live your convictions and know that your actions and beliefs have transformed the lives of millions is at once a humbling and enriching experience. **Your Company is indeed privileged to be able to make a difference, and be recognised for the contribution it makes.** Our abiding Vision, the strength of our outstanding human capital, and our commitment to creating enduring value will continue to inspire us as we strive to achieve even greater success in the future.

On this occasion of your Company's 96th AGM, I would like to once again thank all of you – our valued shareholders – for your unstinted support in our shared journey to create one of India's most valuable corporations. In this journey, I look to you, as always, for your continued support and encouragement.



ITC Limited

Enduring value.

For the nation. For the shareholder.

This is the complete text of
Chairman Y. C. Deveshwar's speech.
The 'video on demand' of the speech can be viewed at
www.itcportal.com.

For a booklet of the speech, please write to the
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